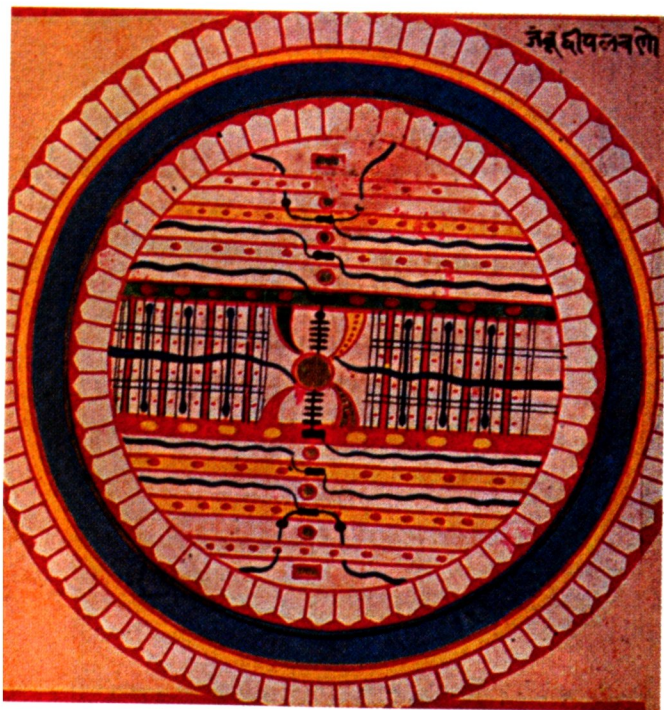




Saints and SENSIBILITY

THE ONLY TWO LANGUAGES THAT ARE UNDERSTOOD ALL OVER THE COUNTRY ARE THE RAMAYANA AND THE MAHABHARATA

BY U.R. ANANTHAMURTHY



PURANIC IDENTITY: Ancient representations of India in the *jamboo-dweepa*

My grandfather, deeply religious and orthodox, would never have said something like "I am an Indian" in his whole life. Yet India was still an idea, a concept derived mostly from her rivers. When he drew water from our well and poured it over his head he recited a mantra which prayed that the waters of the Ganga, Yamuna, Godavari, Saraswati, Narmada and Kaveri be present in the well-water of our home and sanctify him. As he sat for his prayers he positioned himself in the universe beginning with *Bharata-varsha* and then *Bharata-khanda* and then *jamboo-dweepa*, which further got focused into the place he actually sat in and the ever-recurring time according to the lunar almanac. Thus seated, he got all the Gods to dwell in several parts of his body, who enabled him to propitiate Gayatri, a prayer to enhance the psychic energy of the whole of mankind.

Only when I went to my village school did India become a geographical place for me and not just Puranic space. I was told this India was not free, and had been made poor by alien rulers. I was 10 when Gandhiji gave the 'Quit India' call to the British and we sang patriotic songs. Yet India was a mythological place too, for in our hilly villages Sita had lived and she favoured the flower *sital*,